



Spirit of **INDIA**

Youth Special

INNOVATE AND ENRICH

THEY start media networks, work towards advanced crop technologies and train talent in the rural sector.

If for one the power of innovation lies in tapping into the unorganised cycle rickshaw market, for another it lies in providing an online platform for jets. If for one the phrase out-of-the-box refers to a sports management or a backpacking company, for another it translates into selling puja kits. For one, it meant giving up a high-powered job to start his venture, a one-of-a-kind that offers consultancy services in real estate. For an IIT engineer, it was to turn farmer and to work towards production of affordable food and become an inspiration for other farmers in Tamil Nadu. For yet another, the son of a politician, it was to forgo politics and start a media company, giving competition to one of the biggest news agencies in his state. And what about the woman engineer who has dedicated herself to setting up rural BPOS? These are people who prefer to beat the crowd and stand out. These are youngsters who swim against the tide and use unique ideas as a means to change.

"I DIDN'T WANT ANYONE ELSE TO
decide how long I should look at the Eiffel Tower or when I should eat dinner."

YOGESH SHAH, 35, AND SUCHNA HEGDE, 30,
THE BACKPACKER CO

Like any self-respecting Gujarati, Yogesh Shah had his 10 year multiple entry US visa ready even before he discovered that he liked travelling. Ironically, he is now 35 and has been running The Backpacker Co, India's first do-it-yourself travel company for the last two years, but has still not visited the US. That's because he has been busy sending people to Italy, Greece, Spain, Morocco, Poland and other tongue-twisting places in Eastern Europe. "When I was growing up there were only packaged tours. And I didn't want anyone else to decide how long I should look at the Eiffel Tower or when I should eat dinner," says Shah.

That was the essential idea of The Backpacker Co. Shah knew people wanted to travel to places that were off the beaten track but also realised that information was very hard to find. He also knew that his target audience—18 to 30 years—didn't have the deepest pockets. And that is exactly the service his company today provides, advising people on where to go, when and how to travel, where to eat, what to see and how much money one needs to survive every day.

Shah, an HR College graduate, wanted to explore the world beyond Mumbai. "I had my visa and passport ready at all times. I just didn't know how to go and where," he says. When he was 20, an acquaintance told him about his plans to backpack

across Europe. With the money he had saved working in his family's logistics business, Shah took off. "It was supposed to be a 15-day holiday. It turned into two months," he says.

That first trip set the wheels in motion. It was over animated travel tales that Shah and Suchna Hedge decided to tie the knot. But before the two could start a business, they knew they had to sort out the finances. "Besides, it's only now that people are getting used to the idea of independent travel like an impromptu picnic in the Bordeaux region of France or a cycle tour through Amsterdam," he explains. The two travellers have moved into an office space and now have a staff of six. "We still do most of the research ourselves," says Hegde. The couple's business primarily runs on the consultation fee they charge. It started with Rs 1,000 per person two years ago and has gone up to Rs 5,000 now.

But Shah and Hedge are now moving on to the second phase of their venture. They've put in place Travel with Yogi and Suchna, a plan where people travel with them. To make sure that plans take off, the two have in place a Central Europe trip in May and a Mediterranean tour in June where four to five people will take off with the couple. "But it won't end up being a packaged tour. We'll take them but then they can do their own thing," says Shah.

by Jhilmil Motihar

